Athabasca tar sands, the largest of three major oil sand deposits in western Canada. The oil sand deposits lie under thousands of square miles of coniferous forests. The open-pit extraction of oil from tar sands is particularly harmful to the environment. Vast acres of forest are cleared, and ponds of pollutants are left behind. These can leak into the land, rivers, and groundwater, killing fish, migrating birds, and other animals.



Extracting crude oil from Canada's tar sands is notoriously harmful to the environment. It accounts for a tenth of Canada's annual greenhouse gas emissions.